

whatweretheythinking.com

www.hud-son.com

Seriously... what were they thinking? Hudson Forest Equipment, as the name suggests, deals in forest equipment. Since the name hudson.com may have been taken, they've chosen hud-son.com. OK, understandable. But one look beneath the address bar and you will leap with fear. We did.

The top left of the first frame—yes, there are many frames—has a photograph of a forest. Relevant, but it's hugely underexposed and looks tacky. And it gets tackier. The right part of the top frame has links placed one below the other and squeezed.

The second frame is a scroll line that says "Scroll down to view our many products". Thanks for pointing out the obvious! The next

frame shows a flag of France with a link—"Our Canadian Office". Click that, and you are taken to page that's entirely in French, with a link to Freetranslation.com. Whatever.

Scrolling down (as advised—remember?), the shock deepens as seven rows of nearly 40 photos and links appear. These are their products. The background is a deep green (the 'forest' theme all over again), and there are more

scrolling marquees saying a bunch of things.

The real reason we got stuck here was a picture of a newborn in the second frame from top. The caption says "New Addition at Hud-son: Taylor David Hollenbeck". Now, the owner's name is Hudson and the company is Hud-son. Assuming Taylor is a new entry to the Hudson family, why should they ever write about a new addition to Hud-son? Unless this is a new tool we don't know about... once more, we suggest, don't go here. Will you listen?



The mugger was an invincible character controlled by a software bot, and the stolen stuff was sold on a Japanese auction site, *Lineage II* publisher NCsoft claims. So how was the unnamed student able to do this?

The thing is that bots are pretty much invincible in games of this sort—human players don't stand a chance.

If you're wondering what this means, recall that we reported in this space about the game *EverQuest*, where game items can be exchanged for cash.

How this works is people play online and try hard to gather game items. And they value the items so much that they're willing to buy and sell them.

In other words, the players are literally living online: their online experiences are actually translating into trade in the real world. And items can be sold, usually online, for thousands of dollars.

New Scientist quotes security guru Bruce Schneier as noting in his blog: "I

regularly say that every form of theft and fraud in the real world will eventually be duplicated in cyberspace. Perhaps every method of stealing real money will eventually be used to steal imaginary money, too."

Ren Reynolds, a UK-based PC games consultant says, "There's an ongoing war between people who make bots and games companies," Reynolds told *New Scientist*. "And making real money out of virtual worlds is getting bigger."

Reynolds says the growing number of online game players will only increase the incentive for scammers. "There's nothing exceptional about the virtual world. Wherever there is that sort of money, there's always crime too."

There are reports that some online scammers are using 'sweatshops' in China and Indonesia, where people monitor teams of bots to generate money while trying to avoid bot traps! ■

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Blog WATCH

We bring you another eclectic selection of blogs this month: from a bard blogger who dares you to guess his or her identity, to an office-goer who reflects on the experience of e-mailing limericks and finally to funding on RSS in Silicon Valley

Cliques, Clicks, Bullies And Blogs
<http://spaces.msn.com/members/hatefilledchild/>

I am the Walrus

I am one of a long list of people, you shall see. But I will never reveal my true identity. Crack the mystery and you shall win a prize. But beware of my most frequent lies. The name that though call me upon is not that, of which my father titled his son. Some would say that I speak a total of zero Colonel Klink is not fond of my heroes You would know who I am by now, if you'd followed the quest. I hold a golden badge upon my chest. The very person that I most defame is myself Jackson is my name, and I am a shit-dang-woozit-head.....shelf... Or maybe I am none of the above. I may be someone you all hate, or someone you all love. Rest assured my identity will not be found tonight. So you can all just go and fly a fucking kite.

Nina Turns 40

http://ninaturns40.blogs.com/nina_turns_40/

light verse geekitude

I believe I mentioned that we at eVil corp. moved to a new office suite in June, whereby I lost the perk of my own private office and now share a bigger, better-

viewed office with two co-workers. This arrangement has its disadvantages, but one of the fun things about it is that one of the said co-workers is quite funny (he does a kick-ass Kermit THE frog impression which never fails to crack me up). He is young and charming and cute, an advantage to anyone, but what won him a special place in my wee little heart is that he partakes in email limerick smackdowns with me. We fire emails to each other filled with silly limericks composed on the fly. You'd be amazed at how much this relieves stress, and how much joy it brings me... Feeling emboldened by this, I asked him the other day if he liked to write double dactyls. He gave me a look. That look means you've crossed the line from fun, silly, office goofing into pure geekitude. He had no idea WTF I was talking about. Sigh.

Naked Conversations

<http://redcouch.typepad.com/weblog/>

\$100m VC Fund for RSS companies started

Silicon Valley Reporter's Tom Foremski reports: Jim Moore and John Palfrey have launched RSS Investors with \$100m of capital. It is the first VC fund with a focus on Really Simple Syndication, (RSS), the syndication technology at the heart of media technologies such as blogging and corporate news communication.

This shows that at least in some sectors, venture money is getting smarter after several years of demonstrating it had less vision than Ray Charles.